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Abstract

This VoxDevLit reviews research on the roots and development impacts of organised crime. Weak state capacity, dense local social networks, and incentives from illicit markets enable the rise and expansion of criminal organisations. These groups exert territorial control, engage in extortion, recruit children and, in some cases, establish forms of criminal governance and political influence. Their presence has persistent negative effects on economic growth, labour market outcomes, and human capital, while also undermining social trust through violence, corruption, and parallel authority structures. We examine policy responses — including policing reforms, prison rehabilitation, and preventive interventions such as conditional cash transfers, school-based programmes to shift norms or raise labour market expectations, and cognitive behavioural therapy. We highlight that these approaches can show greater effectiveness in reducing violence and recruitment when implemented alongside stronger formal institutions.

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Summary

Organised crime is not a marginal security issue — it is a core development challenge. Where criminal groups gain a foothold, they throttle local growth, discourage private investment, erode human capital and public health, and hollow-out citizen trust in the state. Evidence surveyed in this VoxDevLit shows that homicide rates, school dropout, and forced displacement all rise in territories where mafias, cartels or gangs exert control, while property values, firm creation and formal employment fall. These social costs cumulate: in Italy, long-run GDP per capita is an estimated 16% lower in municipalities infiltrated by the mafia, and Salvadoran neighbourhoods subject to gang 'taxation' pay higher prices for basic goods and suffer worse labour-market outcomes.

Why do criminal organisations thrive?

1. *Weak but present states.* Criminal governance emerges where formal institutions police selectively, adjudicate slowly, or tolerate corruption; it rarely appears in true vacuums.
2. *Lucrative illicit markets and low legal returns*. High profits from drugs, extortion or people smuggling, coupled with limited formal jobs, pull labour and capital into crime.
3. *Social embeddedness*. Dense neighbourhood or prison networks give gangs the cohesion to enforce rules, settle disputes and recruit youths.
4. *Unintended policy spillovers*. Mass deportations, indiscriminate crackdowns and overcrowded prisons have exported criminal 'know-how', fragmented cartels and spread violence rather than containing it.

What works and what backfires.

Heavy-handed, untargeted crackdowns ('kingpin' arrests, militarised sweeps) often splinter hierarchies, ignite turf wars and undermine local legitimacy, even when headline arrests climb. By contrast, *focused deterrence and intelligence-led policing* that concentrate sanctions on the most violent actors while offering off-ramps for those who desist have reduced shootings in multiple high-crime cities. Similarly, *judicial integrity measures* — such as the temporary dismissal of mafia-captured Italian city councils — have spurred employment, entrepreneurship and property values without triggering reprisals. On the preventive side, *conditional cash transfers, unemployment insurance and credible job programmes* raise the opportunity cost of crime and cut recruitment, but they must reach adolescents before gangs do. School-based police patrols in El Salvador, for instance, reduced teenage recruitment and later incarceration by targeting the exact times and places where gangs scout for new members. Interventions that build socio-emotional skills — cognitive-behavioural therapy, after-school tutoring, mentorship — further lower violent behaviour and long-term offending. *Prisons are pivotal*. When overcrowded and ungoverned they become command-and-control hubs; when securely managed and paired with rehabilitation, they disrupt criminal networks and lower recidivism. Isolating high-level bosses, reducing overcrowding, and providing market-relevant training turn prisons from crime incubators into sites of desistance.

Policy principles for lasting impact.

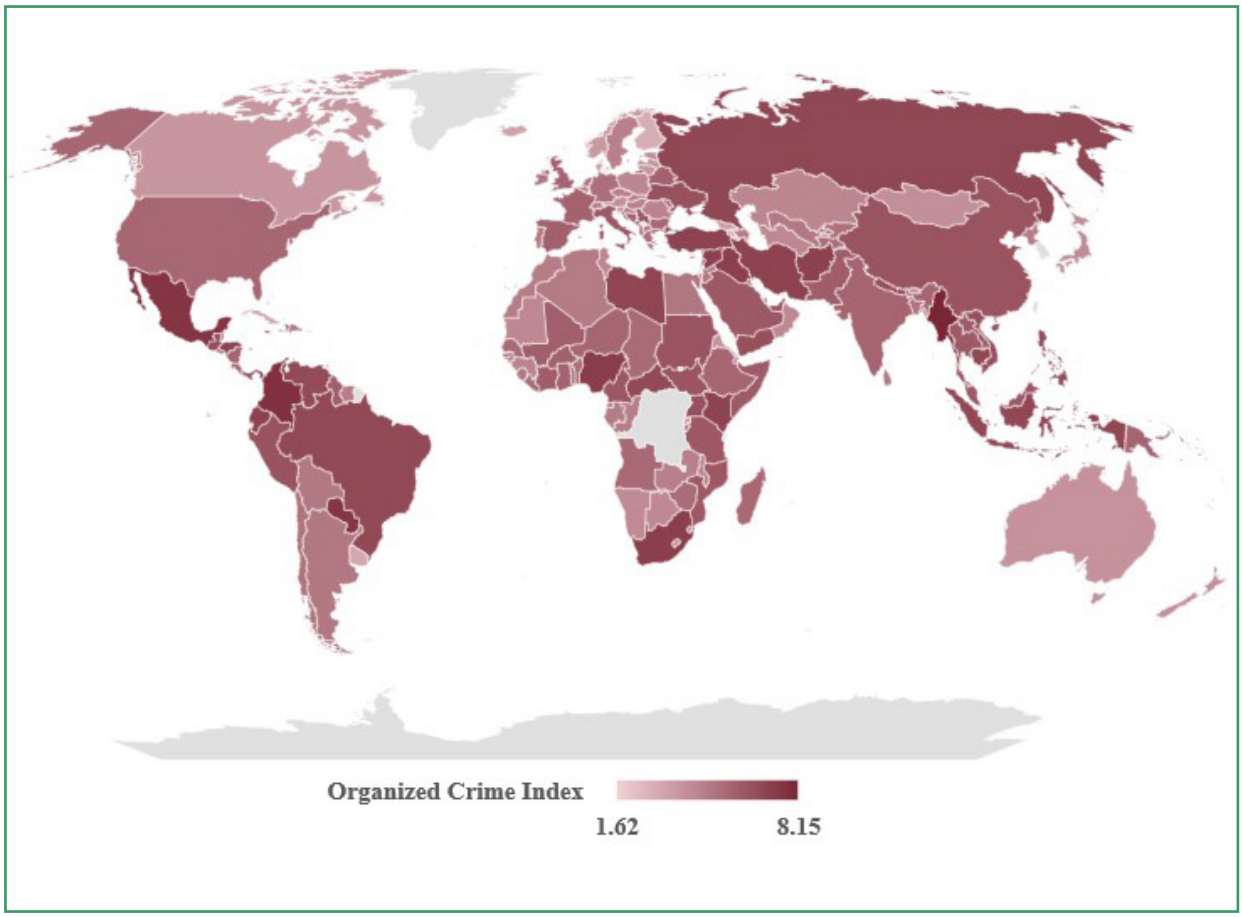
- *Pair smart enforcement with opportunity expansion.* Raise the expected cost of crime and the expected return to legality; one without the other rarely suffices.
- *Start early.* Resources aimed at 12- to 17-year-olds – when recruitment peaks – likely yield the highest marginal returns.
- *Treat extortion like violence.* Criminal taxation saps growth and disproportionately harms the poor; metrics and enforcement should target it explicitly.
- *Strengthen institutions, not just operations.* Transparent procurement, merit-based policing, and timely courts undercut the corruption on which organised crime depends.
- *Make prisons part of the solution.* Secure management plus rehabilitation prevents the cycle of prison-based recruitment and community spillovers.
- *Measure what matters.* Track recruitment, extortion payments and mobility restrictions — not only homicide — to capture the full welfare gains of policy.

1 Introduction

Organised crime consists of durable, profit-seeking associations that coordinate illicit production and trade, enforce their interests through violence or the credible threat of it, corrupt or co-opt state actors, and — where formal authority is weak — impose their own rules, 'taxes', and dispute-resolution mechanisms on the populations and territories they dominate (Gambetta 1996, Acemoglu et al. 2020, Lessing 2021). Organised crime today spans diverse geographies, operating across low-, middle-, and high-income economies, and within political regimes that vary widely in the strength of their institutions. Researchers have recognised that organised crime can influence economic performance, the rule of law, well-being, and broader social and political stability (e.g. Gambetta 1996, Frye and Zhuravskaya 2000, Buonanno et al. 2015, Dell 2015, Alesina et al. 2019, Murphy and Rossi 2020, Melnikov et al. *forthcoming*). In this review, we synthesise recent advances in research on the roots of organised crime, its consequences for development, and the effectiveness of policy interventions aimed at reducing criminal activity and its broader harms. We build on analyses that conceptualise criminal groups as economic agents who respond to incentives shaped by state capacity, formal institutions, community ties, and enforcement policies (e.g. Blattman et al. *forthcoming*, Acemoglu et al. 2020).

To illustrate the global scope and heterogeneity of organised crime, we draw on the 2023 Organized Crime Index developed by the Global Initiative Against Transnational Organized Crime (GI-TOC). This index provides country-level data on criminal markets, criminal actors, state resilience, and the broader socioeconomic context. It reveals that illicit activity spans a range of contexts — including high-income democracies and low-capacity states — challenging the notion that organised crime is confined to fragile or impoverished countries (see Figure 1).

Figure 1 Organized Crime Index - 2023

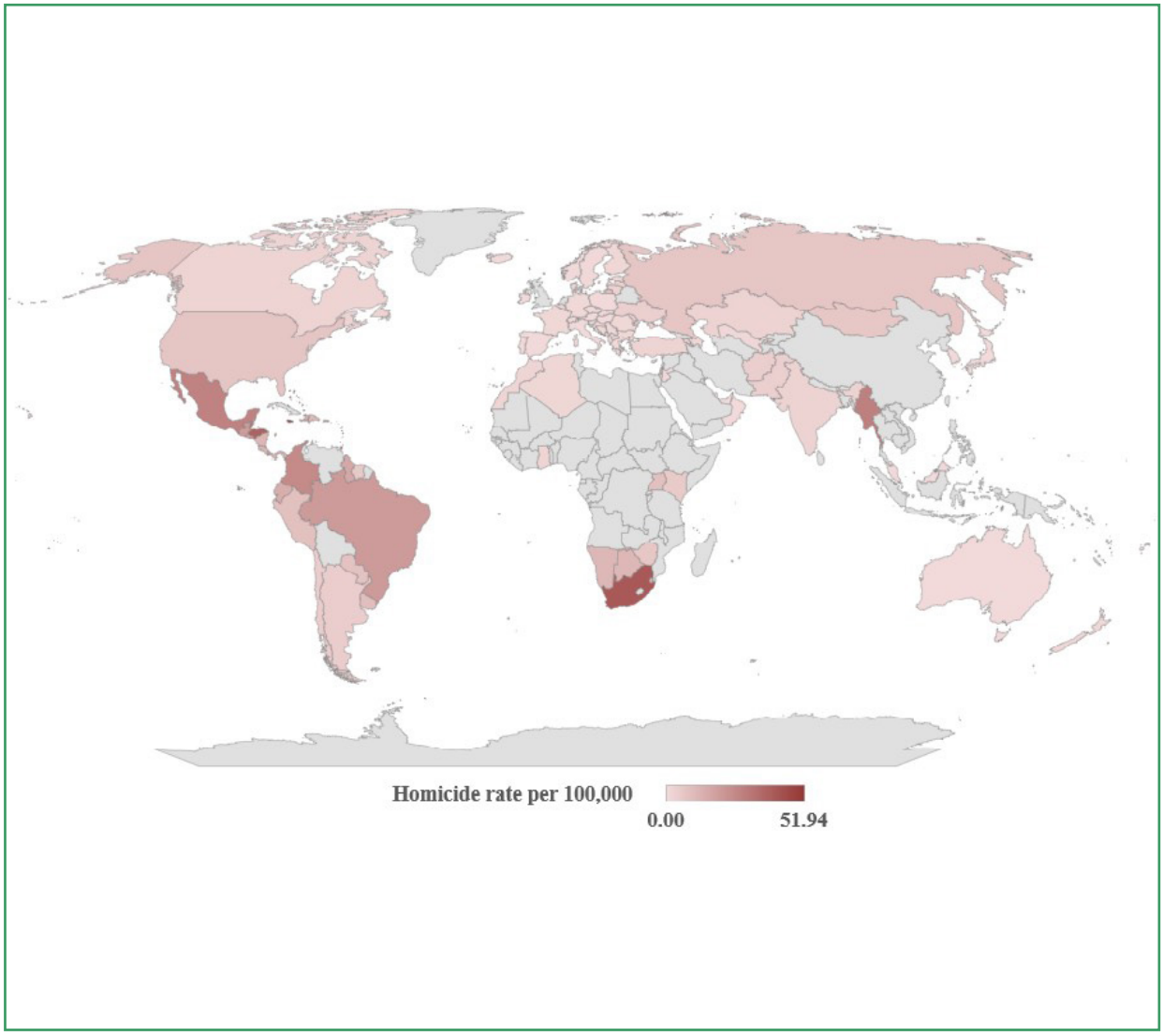


Source: GI-TOC (2023).

In more developed regions, organised crime tends to infiltrate licit markets through mechanisms such as corruption, money laundering, and the misuse of corporate structures, rather than through direct territorial control. In Europe and North America, criminal markets increasingly revolve around cyber-dependent and financial crime activities that often leave few visible traces of violence (GI-TOC 2023). Moreover, high-income countries frequently serve as key destination markets in global trafficking networks. Western Europe, in particular, is a major destination for human and drug trafficking and a hub for financial crimes, and counterfeit goods.

However, as we highlight throughout this review, some of the most severe consequences, such as violence, extortion, human trafficking, and child recruitment, remain concentrated in low- and middle-income countries. Data from GI-TOC shows that Latin America and the Caribbean register high scores on several dimensions of organised crime, especially drug trafficking, extortion, and violence. For instance, the region not only recorded the highest homicide rate of any subregion globally in 2021 (see Figure 2), but also accounted for the largest share of homicides linked to organised crime. The region also reported the highest proportion of homicides involving male victims and firearms. Strikingly, 8 of the 10 countries with the highest homicide rates worldwide were located in Latin America (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime 2023).

Figure 2 Homicide rate per 100,000 citizens – 2021



Source: United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (2023).

Furthermore, studying this region, scholars illustrate how organised crime undermines development through violence, weakened institutions, and the exploitation of vulnerable populations. In Mexico, enforcement strategies that targeted cartel leaders and competition for drug trafficking markets led to fragmentation and turf wars, fuelling sharp increases in violence (e.g. Dell 2015, Calderon et al. 2015, Castillo et al. 2020, Sobrino 2019). Central American nations, especially El Salvador, Guatemala, and Honduras, contend with gangs that emerged partly because of deportations from the United States and weak state capacity due to the past civil conflict (Sviatschi 2022b, Kalsi 2018, Melnikov et al. *forthcoming*). Brazil's favelas have experienced armed conflict between drug gangs and the police, with harmful effects on the community's well-being (Magaloni et al. 2020, Monteiro and Rocha 2017). Scholars also point out that organised crime in these settings has expanded its functions by governing local territories where the state is absent or mistrusted, thus filling a vacuum in security and basic services (Blattman 2025, Lessing 2021).

Moreover, beyond violence, a common feature of criminal organisations in less developed contexts is territorial control for their illicit businesses and the recruitment of children into their ranks (Alarcón Barrera and Sviatschi 2025). Although systematic data on recruitment remains limited, numerous qualitative reports and statements from government officials identify this practice as one of the most pressing challenges. In Peru, increased returns in the illegal sector — particularly in coca-producing regions — have been associated with higher school dropout rates and long-term incarceration risks among boys aged 11 to 14 (Sviatschi 2022a). More recent journalistic and policy reports suggest a growing involvement of minors in organised crime, with 8 out of 9 arrested hitmen in 2024 identified as adolescents and a 36% increase in the national homicide rate (InSight Crime 2025, Infobae 2025). In Ecuador, despite limited academic research, emerging evidence points to an alarming rise in gang-related violence. Between 2019 and 2023, child homicides surged by 640%, a trend linked to targeted killings and expanding gang activity (UNICEF 2024). The recruitment of minors not only perpetuates cycles of violence but also disrupts human capital formation across generations, with long-term consequences for individuals and communities (Castro et al. 2025, Blattman and Annan 2010).

Comparable dynamics are beginning to draw attention in other regions, particularly in West Africa, where organised crime has similarly evolved into a multifaceted threat to governance and development (UNODC 2013). This is mainly due to the contraband flow of cocaine, which meets the rising demand in Europe and whose wholesale value upon arrival often exceeds the national security budgets of many West African countries. However, the report also highlights other threats to the region, including methamphetamine production destined for East Asia, migrant smuggling, firearms trafficking, and maritime piracy (UNODC 2013). Despite the growing concern, there remains a lack of causal evidence on how these criminal dynamics affect broader development outcomes such as state capacity, public service provision, and economic growth.

These cases highlight a broader pattern: despite the significant threat organised crime poses in many low- and middle-income countries, scholarly research in crime has largely focused on developed contexts. As a result, regions facing high levels of violence, child recruitment, and institutional fragility remain underexplored. This review aims to centre the literature on these contexts, while drawing, when appropriate, on insights from research in developed settings to assess how they can be applied — or adapted — to these more contemporary and complex environments.

This review proceeds as follows. Section 2 examines the root causes behind the emergence of organised crime, focusing on the presence of weak states, the role of social identity dynamics, economic incentives, and the unintended outcomes of deportations and incarceration policies. Section 3 looks at consequences for economic development, labour markets, firm behaviour, social outcomes such as violence and human capital, as well as public health, political institutions, corruption, trust, and stability. Section 4 outlines policy interventions, including law enforcement and policing, city council dismissals, prison reforms, and community-based initiatives. We conclude with a discussion of limitations and suggestions for future research.

2 Root Causes of Organised Crime

The literature identifies several root causes for the emergence and persistence of organised crime. Scholars have studied the interactions between state capacity, criminal governance, local socioeconomic conditions, and the expected returns from illicit activities. We distinguish four broad factors: (1) weak state capacity; (2) social identity and community relations; (3) economic incentives and the structure of illicit markets; and (4) inadvertent outcomes of migration, deportations, and incarceration.

2.1 Weak State Capacity

State weakness refers to the limited capacity of governments to perform essential functions such as exercising a monopoly on violence, raising revenue, enforcing laws, regulating markets, and providing public goods. Rather than being an absence of governance, weak states often reflect historical underinvestment in legal and fiscal institutions due to political instability, lack of common-interest public goods, or self-interested elites with short time horizons (Besley and Persson 2009, 2010, Acemoglu 2005). These states frequently coexist with high levels of poverty, criminal governance, and clientelistic or patrimonial authority structures (Besley and Persson 2010, Fergusson et al. 2022). As Fearon and Laitin (2003) argue, such institutional fragility makes non-state armed groups more feasible and attractive by weakening local policing and enabling abusive or ineffective state responses, which can push civilians toward rebel or criminal groups. These dynamics are also evident in contexts like Colombia, where the persistence of paramilitary groups has been shaped by political incentives and electoral benefits, undermining state-building efforts (Acemoglu et al. 2013). Thus, this vacuum of formal authority creates space for private or criminal actors to step in — providing security, collecting informal 'taxes', and arbitrating disputes (Acemoglu et al. 2020, Alesina et al. 2019).

Many authors connect the Sicilian mafia's origins to the incomplete establishment of the central government's monopoly on violence in the late 19th century (Bandiera 2003, Buonanno et al. 2015). In that context, local elites and landowners faced the risk of bandit raids and demanded private protection. Groups that supplied protection developed governance structures that taxed legal activities and enforced local order, thus sowing the seeds of mafia-like organisations (Acemoglu et al. 2020).

In places where official policing is limited, criminal organisations can install themselves as parallel authorities. Blattman et al. (2025) document that in certain neighbourhoods of Medellín, Colombia, gangs manage extortion, mediate disputes, and impose curfews. Over time, these organisations can gain quasi-legitimate authority in the eyes of local residents who see little alternative for security and conflict resolution. Similarly, in Rio de Janeiro's favelas, Magaloni et al. (2020) identify different forms of gang rule, based on fieldwork and surveys. In particular, they highlight that criminal governance structures emerge in areas where state policing is absent, inconsistent, or abusive, leading residents to rely on gangs for protection and basic governance.

In this sense, it is important to note that the mere presence of the state does not guarantee the elimination of organised crime; rather, it is the presence of a strong and capable state that makes the difference. In some instances, criminal organisations operate in localities with a formal security force. Criminal groups may co-opt officials, forge collusion with politicians, or take advantage of local corruption. Blattman et al. (2025) document how increasing state presence in vulnerable and gang-ridden contexts can sometimes incentivise gangs to provide more governance and keep the state out. Buonanno et al. (2016) emphasise that the state can remain weak in key tasks such as policing or judiciary enforcement even when it is present in other domains. This partial presence fosters the rise of criminal governance in targeted markets and neighbourhoods.

Acemoglu et al. (2020) measure the consequences of weak states in Sicily. Using archival data, they show that areas with historically lower state capacity exhibit higher mafia infiltration today, consistent with the argument that criminals step in when official enforcement is limited. In a contemporary context, Dipoppa (2025) also illustrates how criminal organisations can thrive even in strong states. She argues that mafia groups actively expand into well-governed areas by forging strategic alliances with businesses and politicians. Through the provision of illegal labour services and political brokerage — particularly in migrant labour markets — they establish themselves as parallel authorities. In both accounts, incomplete or weak enforcement enabled local power vacuums that mafia groups exploited.

2.2 Social Identity and Neighbourhood-Based Organisation

Some authors suggest that criminal groups rely on social identity for cohesion. The US context provides examples where street gangs tie their membership to neighbourhood identity, ethnicity, or shared experiences of exclusion (Venkatesh and Levitt 2000). Gangs in Nicaragua, El Salvador and Brazil have also been examined through ethnographic methods (Rodgers 2006, Cruz 2010, 2013, Lessing 2021). Scholars argue that in settings where young individuals face limited legitimate opportunities, gangs offer social status, a sense of belonging, and material benefits. These organisations also enforce internal rules that govern members' conduct and manage disputes (Skarbek 2012, 2024). In El Salvador, there is extensive qualitative evidence that, in its origins, gang identity was deeply embedded through rituals, nicknames, tattoos, and the symbolic renunciation of family ties — mechanisms that helped members internalise loyalty and adopt the gang as a surrogate 'family' (Moodie 2010). Cruz (2010) and Cruz (2013) further show that gang membership was often rooted in experiences of social marginalisation and driven by the search for recognition, protection, and solidarity. Similarly, in Brazil, prison gangs such as the Primeiro Comando da Capital (PCC) rely on shared histories, coded language, and ideological messaging to foster internal cohesion and collective action (Lessing 2021). Across these contexts, social identity plays a central role in reducing defection, building trust, and facilitating the organisation of illegal enterprises by aligning individual behaviour with group norms.

At the same time, street-level governance in some cities sometimes emerges from incentives to foster local legitimacy. Gangs might regulate local petty crime, demand 'taxes' from neighbours, and punish theft or violence within their territory (Blattman et al. 2025). They may also supply employment or credit-like arrangements for members, which fosters loyalty. Rodgers (2006) shows that Nicaraguan gang leaders see themselves as community protectors who step in when the official police force is perceived as unresponsive. These findings suggest that organised crime can leverage local social bonds, not just fear or intimidation.

In terms of causal evidence, recent studies have begun to explore the role of social cohesion in shaping the emergence and influence of criminal actors. Sviatschi (2022b) shows that communities with stronger pre-existing social bonds prior to the arrival of gang leaders are more effective at mitigating recruitment. Furthermore, Bandiera et al. (2022) finds that these same communities have experienced lower levels of extortion and gang activity in recent years. Complementing this, evidence from Peru shows that individuals who grew up in environments characterised by stronger moral norms and social cohesion are significantly less likely to engage in criminal behaviour, including participation in organised crime (Guerrero-Trinidad 2025). Similarly, Magaloni et al. (2021) show that Indigenous communities in Mexico, governed through traditional "usos y costumbres" institutions, tend to have significantly lower levels of cartel presence and violence compared to similar areas that rely on formal state security. This resilience seems to stem from their participatory democratic practices, community-led security structures, and parallel justice systems, which together strengthen the community's ability to resist external criminal control.

2.3 Economic Incentives

Illicit markets flourish when demand for illegal goods and services is high and profits exceed the expected cost of law enforcement crackdowns. The crime model developed by Becker (1968) provides a foundational conceptual framework for understanding individuals' decisions to engage in illicit markets. According to this approach, people weigh the potential benefits of committing a crime — considering both expected economic returns and the probability of being detected and punished — against the opportunity costs of forgoing legal market alternatives.

Following this model, an increase in formal employment opportunities should lead to a reduction in crime rates. Recent research provides compelling evidence on the role of labour market conditions in shaping individual involvement in criminal organisations. Carvalho and Soares (2016) analyse how drug trafficking and local unemployment shape the incentives of young people to join gangs in Brazilian favelas. They argue that the opportunity cost of illegal activities is lower when legal labour markets fail to offer stable income. Similarly, Dell et al. (2019) find that job losses in the manufacturing sector — driven by trade competition with China — lowered the opportunity cost of engaging in illicit activities such as drug trafficking, particularly among young men with low levels of education. Dube et al. (2016) also show that fluctuations in commodity prices, such as maize, can influence cartel entry into certain areas, as it becomes more profitable to shift from legal agriculture to illicit crops or from low-wage labour to drug trafficking. Likewise, Khanna et al. (2023) find that higher costs of formal employment in Medellín led to reduced participation in the formal sector and increased recruitment into criminal organisations. Together, these findings reinforce the idea that weak formal labour markets can push individuals — especially youth — toward structured criminal networks.

While improved opportunities in the legal sector can steer individuals away from criminal groups, there is also causal evidence that higher returns in illegal markets can pull individuals into illicit activities. In Peru, Sviatschi (2022a) finds that early exposure to illegal labour markets linked to the cocaine trade leads to diminished accumulation of formal human capital. Combined with the development of crime-specific skills, this exposure significantly increases the likelihood of long-term engagement in organised crime. The impact is particularly severe for children between the ages of 11 and 14, who — driven by high returns in the illegal sector — are more likely to drop out of school and engage in illegal activities, such as coca processing and drug trafficking. The long-term implications are substantial: individuals exposed at a young age are approximately 30% more likely to be incarcerated for violent or drug-related offenses as adults, compared to those not exposed to these environments. The study attributes this outcome to the formation of sector-specific human capital – that is, skills and connections that reduce the barriers to sustained participation in criminal activities.

At the same time, recent research has also shown how expected returns in the illicit sector can affect youth decisions to get involved in gangs. In particular, Blattman et al. (2025) examine how early exposure to gangs and beliefs about gang life in Colombia influence youths' educational aspirations and interest in criminal activity — demonstrating that information and perception can shift behaviour. Over time, these dynamics could contribute to a criminal pipeline from disadvantaged neighbourhoods into gang structures. This underscores the importance of early interventions in schools during key developmental stages to disrupt the cycle of recruitment. However, as we will discuss in the section on policy responses, there is a notable lack of interventions specifically targeting these critical age groups.

These cases illustrate how economic incentives, labour market constraints, and human capital formation interact to sustain and deepen participation in organised crime over time.

2.4 Inadvertent Policy Impacts

2.4.1 Deportations and Migration

Scholars have also examined how US deportation policies — particularly those targeting criminal offenders — impact receiving communities in migrants' countries of origin (Sviatschi 2022b, Kalsi 2018, Ambrosius and Leblang 2025, Rozo et al. 2021). In the case of El Salvador, mass deportations of gang members from the United States in the 1990's significantly contributed to the expansion of violent gangs. Sviatschi (2022b) shows that US-based gang networks extended their reach into Central America following large-scale deportations. Deported individuals, often with established ties and organisational knowledge, played a central role in founding and structuring new gang cells. Exploiting variation in the birthplace of gang leaders, the study finds that communities receiving deported gang leaders experienced increases in homicides, extortion, and the presence of individuals with US gang affiliations. Kalsi (2018) and Sviatschi (2022b) also highlight that these dynamics can disrupt children's educational outcomes and heighten their vulnerability to gang recruitment.

Migration flows themselves can also be exploited by criminal groups as channels for territorial expansion and the transfer of criminal capital. Murphy and Rossi (2020) demonstrate that early 20th-century Chinese migration to Mexico helped introduce poppy cultivation, laying the groundwork for future cartel activity. More recently, the mass migration crisis from Venezuela has provided a new opportunity for organised crime to expand their reach. Initially extracting rents from migrant smugglers, Venezuelan gangs — most notably the prison-based group Tren de Aragua — have evolved into vertically integrated actors that control multiple aspects of the migration corridor. Qualitative evidence suggests that these groups now manage transportation routes, extort migrants, and run temporary lodging operations across countries such as Mexico, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, and Chile (El País 2023, Insight Crime 2023). Guerrero and Sviatschi (2025) provide causal evidence of this evolution. Leveraging the timing of Peru's imposition of migration restrictions on Venezuelan nationals, they show that these restrictions facilitated the expansion of Tren de Aragua's operations beyond Venezuela due to an increased demand for migrant smugglers. Their analysis finds that this expansion led to significant increases in extortion, human trafficking, and sexual exploitation, particularly in areas where migrants concentrated — such as informal settlements, transport hubs, and temporary shelters. Relatedly, Cabra-Ruiz et al. (2024) also provide evidence on how the migration crisis increased violent events related to criminal organisations in Venezuela. A similar situation happened in Colombia, where Venezuelan migration increased homicides near the border, primarily affecting migrants as victims (Knight and Tribin 2023).

These studies highlight how international policy decisions can produce unintended consequences by fuelling the expansion of organised crime in developing regions — particularly where state capacity is weak or unprepared to respond effectively. Moreover, they show how criminal capital — such as networks, knowledge and reputational power — can be transferred across geographic areas. In this context, further evidence is needed to understand whether legal migration pathways can curb the growth of migrant smuggling networks by reducing demand for their services. Moreover, there is no causal evidence on how the expansion of criminal organisations into human trafficking specifically affects women.

2.4.2 Mass Incarceration

Large-scale incarceration policies have produced unintended consequences for the dynamics of organised crime. A growing body of research shows that prisons often serve as incubators where inmates form criminal networks, adopt gang identities, and engage in illicit trades (Lessing 2017a, Skarbek 2012, Tobón 2022, Escobar et al. 2023, Durlauf and Nagin 2011). Upon release, these individuals frequently maintain ties formed behind bars, reinforcing gang structures in their communities — as documented in Colombia by Escobar et al. (2023). Lessing (2017a) argues that harsh crackdowns may even strengthen prison gangs, enabling them to coordinate with external actors, enforce discipline, or escalate violence.

Recent evidence from Ecuador further highlights this spillover effect: released offenders significantly increase local crime (Jaramillo 2024). In addition to becoming schools of crime, a recent review highlights how many prisons across Latin America and the Caribbean have effectively become criminal hubs, facilitating criminal activities and strengthening criminal organisations across the region (Schargrodsky and Tobon 2025).

Researchers have also pointed out that incarceration might reinforce gang identity and loyalty. Skarbek (2012, 2024) shows how gangs in US prisons enforce a code of conduct through internal courts or violent punishments. Similar patterns appear in Latin America, where prison gang leaders continue to manage operations outside the prison walls (Lessing and Denyer Willis 2019). Thus, efforts to remove criminals from the streets may inadvertently enable the formation of sophisticated organisational structures in prisons. While most of the research is descriptive, more research is needed to understand the mechanisms for which criminal organisations expand using prisons. In particular, if released offenders may diffuse the influence of prison-based criminal organisations through family and peer networks.

3 Consequences of Organised Crime

Organised crime exerts major effects on economic development, social outcomes, and community well-being. In this section, we discuss the impacts on growth, employment, firm dynamics, investment, violence, human capital, and public health. A consistent finding across many studies is that criminal networks impose large social and economic costs, although the mechanisms differ across contexts.

3.1 Economic Outcomes

3.1.1 Economic Activity

A strand of work in development economics asks how criminal organisations affect long-run development. Pinotti (2015) studies the Italian mafia and finds that areas with higher mafia presence exhibit systematically lower growth rates in formal economic activity. The mafia's reliance on extortion, intimidation, and infiltration of local businesses can distort resource allocation and deter entrepreneurship. Melnikov et al. (*forthcoming*) analyse how gang presence influences labour mobility and development outcomes. They show that gang territorial control can disrupt labour flows and affect the spatial allocation of productive firms in the country. Specifically, gangs impose mobility restrictions to prevent informants from the police or rival gangs from entering into their territory. As a consequence of these restrictions, residents are not able to commute to areas with better job opportunities, thereby limiting access to broader labour markets. The authors find that these constraints have long-term consequences for earnings and human capital accumulation. The authors emphasise that the economic costs of these mobility barriers accumulate over time, especially as non-gang areas experience higher employment growth — making access to those opportunities increasingly critical.

Fenizia and Saggio (2024) also find evidence on the negative effects of the mafia. Analysing Italian municipalities, they show that removing mafia influence via city council dismissals leads to significant increases in employment, firm creation, and property prices, particularly in sectors previously dominated by the mafia. Their results suggest that city council dismissals weaken the mafia's ability to enforce monopolies. Slutzky and Zeume (2018) find similar evidence that anti-mafia enforcement efforts increase competition and innovation in affected municipalities in Italy. In the same way, Ganau and Rodríguez-Pose (2018) show that organised crime is negatively associated with firm productivity growth in Italy. Lastly, Daniele and Marani (2011) find that mafia-related crime is negatively correlated with foreign direct investment (FDI) across Italian provinces. Even after accounting for financial incentives, higher levels of organised crime appear to deter foreign investors, likely by signalling a weak or unfavourable socio-institutional environment.

Furthermore, while organised crime typically undermines economic activity, some evidence suggests it can also play a more complex role. In Mexico, Murphy and Rossi (2020) find that areas with a history of illicit agriculture — shaping contemporary cartel presence — exhibit higher community-level socioeconomic outcomes, indicating that cartels may sometimes act as alternative governance providers. Similarly, Le Moglie and Sorrenti (2022) show that during the 2008 financial crisis, Italian provinces with stronger mafia presence experienced smaller drops in new business formation, suggesting that organised crime may have injected illicit capital into the formal economy when conventional credit sources contracted.

3.1.2 Labour Market Effects

Violence and extortion by organised crime can disrupt labour markets. Firms may reduce hiring, relocate, or shut down. Workers may migrate to safer locations or remain unemployed if they perceive high risks during commutes or in the workplace (e.g. Aldeco et al. 2024, Melnikov et al. *forthcoming*). Velásquez (2020) shows that increases in local homicide rates significantly reduce self-employment among women and lower earnings for self-employed men. The results suggest that fear of crime alters occupational choices and suppresses income, especially among informal workers, highlighting the broader economic costs of violence by drug cartels. Relatedly, Brown et al. (2019) investigate how exposure to violent crime during Mexico's drug war influenced individuals' risk preferences. They find that as local-area violent crime increased, individuals' risk aversion also rose significantly, which could potentially depress entrepreneurial activity.

Criminal organisations can also impose a parallel form of 'taxation' on labour-intensive sectors such as distribution firms and public transport (Konrad and Skaperdas 1998, Martínez et al. 2016, Ponce et al. 2016, Magaloni et al. 2020, Brown et al. 2025, Estefan and Ordonez 2024). Brown et al. (2025) study how gang competition shapes extortion using a novel dataset from a large wholesale distributor in El Salvador, linking approximately 50,000 extortion payments to firm-level sales. They show that while reduced gang competition lowers homicide rates, it simultaneously increases extortion, leading to higher consumer prices and adverse health outcomes. These findings underscore a trade-off between lower violence and higher criminal rents, with significant downstream effects on welfare. Similarly, Estefan and Ordonez (2024) document that in Guatemala, extortion distorts markets by limiting competition and boosting rents for incumbent firms. Balletta et al. (2019) further demonstrate that smaller firms in Italy pay a higher proportion of their profits as extortion fees compared to larger firms. This regressive taxation discourages market entry and fosters concentration, as smaller firms are often priced out by cumulative extortion costs. Complementing this, Piemontese (2023) uses a structural estimation model to quantify the economic cost of mafia extortion in Northern Italy, finding that extortion reduces firm-level output by 0.5% to 5%, causing resource misallocation and welfare losses. The impact intensifies with multiple extortion demands from different criminal groups, further deterring investment and business expansion.

In addition to suppressing employment and income, organised crime can also shape wage inequality by affecting labour supply and capital allocation. Using a general equilibrium model, Pi and Zhang (2020) show that when unskilled or both skilled and unskilled workers participate in crime, wage inequality increases if the skilled sector is more capital intensive and demand for skilled labour is highly elastic. If only skilled workers are involved, inequality rises regardless of demand conditions.

Criminal organisations can also influence firm dynamics through other multiple and complex channels beyond extortion. Arellano-Bover et al. (2024) examine the infiltration of Italy's legal economy by organised crime, identifying three distinct motives: a functional motive, where firms are used to carry out criminal operations; a competitive motive, where existing firms are co-opted to enhance market power through illicit means; and a pure or relational motive, wherein large, reputable firms are infiltrated to gain access to influential political or economic networks. The latter represents a novel contribution, emphasising how criminal groups can strategically exploit legitimate firms without directly engaging them in criminal activities. Complementing this evidence, Fenizia and Saggio (2024) show that mafia infiltration at the municipal level in Italy leads to lower rates of firm entry, reduced investment in capital-intensive industries, and greater reliance on informal arrangements. Mirenda et al. (2022) also show that mafia infiltration in legal sectors can reduce competition, hamper formal entrepreneurship, and reinforce local monopolies.

Barone and Narciso (2015) further document that business subsidies in mafia-affected regions are partly diverted to criminal networks, weakening public policy efforts to stimulate local development. Beyond infiltration, organised crime can actively shape local market structures. In Brazil, drug gangs are found to regulate entry and exit in retail markets, using violence and intimidation to maintain monopolistic control and suppress outside competition (Cavgias et al. 2023). A similar pattern occurs in Medellín, Colombia, where criminal organisations monopolise legal goods markets such as dairy products, eggs or gas canisters (Blattman et al. 2025). Such interventions distort market dynamics and hinder local economic growth.

Finally, criminal organisations can also influence firm dynamics through the use of violence. Violent competition among criminal groups generates heightened uncertainty, disrupts supply chains, and suppresses productive economic activity. Rozo (2018) finds that in Colombia, surges in violence linked to organised crime compel firms to reduce output or exit the market altogether, resulting in lower real wages for workers in affected areas.

3.2 Social Outcomes

3.2.1 Violence and Social (Di)stability

Violence is perhaps the most visible manifestation of organised crime's presence. Patterns of rising violence are frequently linked to state enforcement approaches and the political alliances that underpin them. For instance, Dell (2015) demonstrates that political victories by Mexico's PAN party diverted trafficking routes, escalating violence along alternative corridors as rival groups fought to gain control. Castillo and Kronick (2020) reinforce these findings, arguing that poorly targeted crackdowns increase criminal profits and make kingpins more short-sighted, fuelling further violence. Only by targeting the most violent actors can the state reduce violence without exacerbating supply or conflict.

State interventions can also unintentionally destabilise criminal equilibrium. Calderón et al. (2015) show that Mexico's strategy of targeting cartel leadership, especially kingpins, disrupted existing balances of power, sparking both intra- and inter-cartel wars. These leadership removals had immediate effects on drug-related violence and spillovers to civilian homicides, particularly in municipalities within the trafficking network. Complementing this view, Phillips (2015) finds that while decapitation strategies may yield short-term reductions in violence when mid-level leaders are arrested, they often lead to long-term increases as fragmented groups compete to regain market control. Notably, violence rises more when leaders are killed than when they are arrested.

Additional evidence shows that state enforcement often generates unintended spillover effects that intensify violence. Castillo et al. (2020) document how seizures of cocaine shipments from Colombia to Mexico lead to increased violence in Mexican municipalities where cocaine becomes scarce. Osorio (2015) finds that crackdowns in areas with dense criminal presence exacerbate inter-organisational conflicts and lead to the spatial diffusion of violence. Rios (2013) further describes this pattern as a "self-reinforcing violent equilibrium", where repression and cartel rivalries mutually escalate, fuelling rising homicide rates. Moreover, Atuesta and Ponce (2017) highlight how enforcement efforts — particularly those targeting criminal leadership — provoke organisational fragmentation, spawning smaller, more volatile groups that violently compete for control. Although the pace of violence may eventually slow as fragmentation deepens, the immediate effects are destabilising and prolong cycles of conflict.

Beyond state-led interventions, internal criminal dynamics also contribute to violence. Bruhn et al. (2021) show that gang violence is shaped by internal cohesion and market competition: more fragmented or competitive environments tend to produce more violence, pointing to the role of behavioural and social dynamics in shaping outcomes beyond simple market models.

Another important driver of violence is the increasing value of certain commodities and the territories that produce them. Sobrino (2019) finds that rising US heroin demand prompted cartels to expand into municipalities with favourable conditions for cultivation and transport, triggering local surges in violence. Similarly, Mejia and Restrepo (2013) and Millán-Quijano (2020) show that higher cocaine prices are associated with more conflict in Colombia. In Afghanistan, Gehring et al. (2023) uses heroin price data to link drug market fluctuations to armed conflict. Theoretical models also support these observations: as the value of a territory rises, so do the incentives for turf wars between competing criminal actors (Bueno de Mesquita 2020, Castillo and Kronick 2020).

However, commodity booms do not always lead to greater violence. Sánchez de la Sierra (2020) shows that in eastern Congo, rising coltan and gold prices led to the emergence of criminal actors who, rather than engage in open conflict, established monopolies of violence and forms of governance around mining sites and nearby villages. These groups implemented taxation, regulated labour, and provided protection — state-like functions that stabilised order. This case highlights that resource booms may drive violence or governance, depending on whether a monopoly or competition for control emerges.

Finally, despite their violent capacities, criminal organisations can also foster social stability under specific conditions. In Brazil, Biderman et al. (2019) finds that monopoly control by a single gang significantly reduces violence. A similar dynamic unfolded in Medellín, Colombia, where a 2013 non-aggression pact, El Pacto del Fusil, between two non-state armed confederations (*La Oficina* and the *Clan del Golfo*) lowered homicide rates to roughly 12 per 100,000 by 2024. This informal arrangement, driven by mutual business interests rather than state action, coordinated hundreds of local street gangs that regulated drug sales, collect extortion payments, and mediate disputes. Yet such peace is often fragile. In El Salvador, a 2016 gang truce similarly reduced violence but raised extortion by 20%, inflating prices of essential goods like pharmaceuticals (Brown et al. 2025). These examples reveal that while criminal coordination can suppress violence, it often entrenches monopolistic rent extraction.

3.3.2 Human Capital

Organised crime can hinder human capital development through multiple interrelated pathways. Communities exposed to high levels of violence often experience substantial disruptions to schooling. Violence can undermine the provision of education and significantly influence the behaviours and decisions of students, parents, teachers, and school administrators. Monteiro and Rocha (2017), using data from Rio de Janeiro, show that children perform worse on standardised tests during periods of intense drug gang warfare. Specifically, the study identifies disruptions in the supply of education as a critical channel through which conflict affects student outcomes: exposure to armed violence is significantly correlated with elevated teacher absenteeism, increased principal turnover, and the temporary suspension of school operations. Similarly, Brown and Velásquez (2017) find that the expansion of drug cartel activity in Mexico is associated with lower educational attainment and higher employment among young adults. This shift in behaviour appears to be driven primarily by household financial hardship rather than individual preferences.

Beyond institutional disruptions and household economic responses, exposure to violence can also have profound effects on students' psychological well-being and attitudes, which in turn influences learning outcomes. Chronic exposure to violent environments is linked to increased anxiety, stress, and trauma, all of which negatively affect cognitive development and academic performance (Michaelsen and Salardi 2020). Koppensteiner and Menezes (2021) show that exposure to local homicides in Brazil leads to declines in test scores, reduced school attendance, and increased dropout rates, effects that are particularly pronounced among boys from low-income families and largely driven by diminished educational aspirations and motivation.

The presence of criminal organisations can also distort local economic incentives, lower the perceived returns to education, and increase the recruitment of children into illicit activities. In such environments, children may come to view criminal work as more profitable or socially rewarding than low-wage legal employment. Evidence from El Salvador shows that children living in gang-controlled neighbourhoods are more likely to drop out of school and perform worse on standardised tests than those in nearby non-gang areas (Melnikov et al. *forthcoming*, Sviatschi 2022b). Similarly, in Peru, when the profitability of illegal activities rises — particularly in coca-growing regions — children are more likely to engage in this work, increasing their risk of becoming involved in drug trafficking (Sviatschi 2022a).

A third mechanism involves forced displacement: violent confrontations may push families to migrate, interrupting schooling (Aldeco et al. 2024). Over time, these factors reduce average levels of human capital, which in turn hinders economic development.

3.2.3 Public Health

Organised crime affects public health through both direct and indirect channels, as highlighted by a growing body of qualitative evidence. Directly, it generates fear, anxiety, and psychological distress, prompting behavioural changes within affected communities. These effects often extend beyond immediate victims, influencing broader patterns of mental well-being, physical activity, and consumption of goods and services (Lorenc et al. 2012, 2014). Indirectly, organised crime can weaken the institutional foundations necessary for effective public health policy by undermining law enforcement, regulatory frameworks, and tax collection — key components for financing and implementing health interventions (Reynolds and McKee 2010). While cross-national quantitative evidence remains limited, emerging research from Latin America and the Caribbean offers valuable insights into the public health consequences of organised crime. Country-level studies help illustrate how these mechanisms operate in practice, particularly in regions where organised criminal groups exert substantial territorial and institutional control.

In Mexico, where violence has escalated due to drug trafficking organisations, Villarreal and Yu (2017) document how surges in homicide rates heighten fear and psychological distress, even for those not directly exposed to violence. In Brazil, fear resulting from organised crime violence can also reduce the use and access to specific public services. Pecanha et al. (2024) show that urban violence can significantly disrupt the use of public health services. Using monthly clinic-level data from Rio de Janeiro, they find that each police-related shooting leads to a 12% drop in primary care procedures, particularly on the day of the event. These effects are more pronounced in low-income neighbourhoods, highlighting how exposure to violence not only limits access to essential services but also exacerbates existing inequalities.

Furthermore, reductions in violence do not necessarily eliminate the broader health impacts associated with organised crime. Criminal groups can influence health outcomes through alternative mechanisms – most notably through extortion. Brown et al. (2025) find that while a period of gang collusion in El Salvador led to a reduction in overt violence, it was accompanied by a significant rise in extortion. This increase in criminal taxation elevated the prices of pharmaceuticals, contributing to higher rates of hospital visits for chronic illnesses. In addition to extortion, organised crime can directly affect population health through drug trafficking. Pereira et al. (2025) show that surges in drug trafficking activity across municipalities in Brazil were associated with increased overdose-related mortality, indicating a rise in drug consumption among the local population.

Although this review does not cover all forms of politically or religiously motivated crimes, related evidence offers valuable insights. In Israel, Becker and Rubinstein (2011) show that suicide bombings by religious terrorist groups significantly reduce bus usage, especially among occasional riders and less-educated families. These groups face lower economic incentives to confront fear and are more influenced by media coverage. The study finds that the psychological impact is amplified when attacks are followed by regular news cycles, while attacks occurring before holidays — when media attention is limited — have little effect. These results highlight how fear, shaped by both violence and media exposure, can meaningfully alter everyday behaviour.

Finally, as we mentioned earlier, the rigorous causal evidence on the specific public health effects of organised crime remains limited. Most existing studies focus on general crime or violence, without distinguishing whether perpetrators are part of organised criminal networks. This is largely due to the difficulty of identifying which crimes are specifically attributable to organised criminal groups, rather than to common delinquency. Nonetheless, this broader literature consistently reveals negative impacts on both physical and mental health. For instance, Dustmann and Fasani (2016) find that exposure to local crime increases psychological distress in the United Kingdom, especially among women, while Cornaglia et al. (2014) report declines in mental well-being linked to violent crime in Australia. Similarly, Janke et al. (2016) show that violent crime reduces physical activity in England, and Hamermesh (1999) documents how crime alters work behaviour in the United States.

3.2.4 Housing and Distributional Effects

Criminal organisations can impose regressive economic costs on communities, disproportionately affecting low-income populations. Ajzenman et al. (2015) provide evidence from Mexico showing that drug-related violence significantly reduces housing values in poorer neighbourhoods, while property prices in wealthier areas remain largely unaffected. Their estimates suggest that increased homicide rates led to a cumulative loss of approximately USD 600 million in housing wealth, underscoring the unequal distribution of the economic burden associated with violence. Similarly, in El Salvador, gang presence has been shown to concentrate negative externalities — such as reduced economic activity and higher prices in subsistence goods — in marginalised urban areas, further entrenching spatial inequality (Melnikov et al. *forthcoming*, Brown et al. 2025, International Crisis Group 2017).

3.3 Governance, Corruption, and Public Trust

Organised crime engages with political systems in diverse and complex ways. Scholars have explored how state and non-state illegal armed groups influence elections, alter the trust and perception of formal institutions, or interact strategically with political actors (Berrebi and Klor 2008, Gallego 2018, Osorio et al. 2018, Alesina et al. 2019, Campedelli et al. 2023). We structure this section around three key areas: (1) criminal governance, (2) corruption, and (3) trust in formal institutions.

3.3.1 Criminal Governance

Criminal governance refers to the imposition of rules or behavioural restrictions by a criminal organisation over various actors, including its own members, other criminal actors, and non-criminal civilians (Lessing 2021). Rather than viewing organised crime as merely profit-oriented, this perspective emphasises the role of norms and institutional structures in shaping how criminal groups exert control. Criminal organisations do not merely operate in illicit markets — they often shape the lives, routines, and expectations of the populations they interact with by enforcing norms, adjudicating disputes, providing order, and sometimes delivering public goods. Yet not all forms of criminal activity constitute governance. A gang that extorts residents or occupies a street corner without regulating behaviour or providing services should not be understood as governing. As Lessing (2021) argues, using the term “governance” too broadly, such as for cases where criminal organisations only protect their own interests, weakens its meaning. What makes criminal governance analytically useful is that these groups go beyond managing their own members or businesses; they impose rules on outsiders, including civilians and other actors in their territory.

Criminal governance resembles, but also diverges fundamentally from, other forms of governance, including corporate governance, state-building, and rebel rule. Some of the most sophisticated criminal organisations exhibit corporate features — internal hierarchies, recruitment strategies, and complex management systems — but unlike licit firms, their authority often extends to entire communities or illicit markets (Lessing 2021). Still, this authority is not analogous to state-making. Though scholars have long used metaphors of state formation to understand organised crime (Blok 1974, Hobsbawm 1969, Tilly 2017), these comparisons often obscure key distinctions. Criminal organisations rarely challenge state authority; instead, they govern in the intersections of state power (Yashar 2018), in spaces shaped by state repression, such as illicit markets or prisons.

Even rebel governance — perhaps the closest conceptual analogue — differs in its goal of competitive state-building (Kalyvas 2006, Kasfir 2015, Arjona 2016). Criminal groups, by contrast, govern without seeking sovereignty or formal state power. Their governance is partial, often overlapping with state functions, and may even coexist symbiotically with state institutions. As such, criminal governance cannot be understood apart from the state — it is simultaneously enabled by its absences and constrained by its presence (Koivu 2018, Gambetta 1996).

Empirical studies across different regions help clarify how this kind of criminal rule operates on the ground. When the state is weak, absent, or corrupt, criminal groups often step in to fill the gap. They enforce rules, resolve disputes, and provide basic order — functions that are usually expected from the state. In many neighbourhoods of Rio de Janeiro or Sao Paulo, for instance, militias or drug gangs hold de facto power over day-to-day life, shaping local norms and policing crime through informal justice systems (Magaloni et al. 2020; Lessing and Denyer Willis 2019). Complementing this, ethnographic research in Rio de Janeiro has shown how different types of criminal organisations contribute to distinct models of social control in the city's favelas. Drawing on years of fieldwork and hundreds of interviews, scholars have documented how both drug gangs in the Zona Norte and militias in the Zona Oeste build varying relationships with residents — ranging from coercive to responsive forms of rule — that shape the daily social, economic, and political life of these communities (Arias 2006, Arias and Barnes 2017, Barnes 2025).

Scholars have also explored how local communities navigate and adapt to the presence of criminal governance. In Medellín, residents often view criminal groups as more reliable providers of security than the official police, who are frequently absent or abusive (Blattman et al. 2025). This perception is not only a reflection of loss in state trust but also illustrates how criminal governance adapts to local conditions. As Blattman et al. (2025) show, in neighbourhoods with high potential for drug rent, gangs responded to the presence of the state by expanding their provision of governance services, such as regulating violence, resolving disputes or offering protection. These patterns suggest that both repression and engagement by state actors can reshape the behaviour of criminal organisations. In doing so, the state may unintentionally reinforce or undermine localised forms of criminal rule, highlighting the dynamic interplay between state authority and criminal governance.

Beyond Latin America, scholars have also documented similar forms of criminal or armed governance in other regions. In eastern Congo, for example, Sánchez de la Sierra (2020) shows how roving warlords transformed into stationary bandits who provided security and justice when mineral rents were high and easily taxable. These armed actors, although capable of arbitrary violence, sometimes established localised monopolies of force, set up taxation systems, and administered justice — functions typically associated with states. When sustained expropriation was profitable, these groups even developed rudimentary fiscal administrations. In some contexts, such as parts of the DRC, the presence of these actors could paradoxically improve household welfare — particularly when the value of protection outweighed the costs of informal taxation and when their incentives aligned with the interests of local populations.

Complementing these findings, Lessing and Denyer Willis (2019) analyse the internal governance system of Brazil's Primeiro Comando da Capital, showing how the group maintains territorial control through mild but well-regulated punishments and a consignment-based drug trade. Taken together, these studies illustrate that criminal actors do not merely seek to capture the state from within; in some cases, they establish parallel forms of authority that substitute or coexist with formal institutions — blurring the line between political influence and criminal governance.

Finally, as the following subsections will explore, criminal governance not only shapes local order but also influences electoral dynamics, facilitates corruption through collusion with state officials, and ultimately undermines public trust in the rule of law.

3.3.2 Electoral Processes

Criminal organisations may infiltrate politics by supporting particular candidates or threatening their opponents. In the case of Italy, researchers have documented how politicians form alliances with criminal networks in exchange for electoral advantages or protection (Buonanno et al. 2016, Daniele and Dipoppa 2017). Alesina et al. (2019) provide additional evidence showing that Italian mafia groups collaborate with local politicians during elections to secure favourable policies or protection from law enforcement. These alliances can undermine democratic accountability and distort public spending, as elected officials may feel compelled to reciprocate support through discretionary contracts or by limiting police intervention. Furthermore, Dal Bó et al. (2006) offer a theoretical model in which criminal groups influence public policy through a mix of bribes and threats — capturing the strategic logic behind many of these interactions.

While alliances with politicians represent one channel of influence, criminal organisations may also shape political outcomes more indirectly through violence, intimidation, and the exercise of criminal governance. In Italy, Daniele and Dipoppa (2017) show that mafia groups often target local politicians with violence after elections in order to condition government activities. In El Salvador, criminal control over territory affects political participation through multiple mechanisms. Cordova (2019) finds that gang dominance reduces both electoral and non-electoral political engagement, discouraging citizens from voting or seeking assistance from public officials. Similarly, Baires et al. (2025) show that the effects of the Residential Voting reform — designed to boost turnout by assigning voters to their nearest polling place — were highly uneven: while turnout and economic activity rose in areas without gangs, the reform's benefits were offset in gang-controlled zones where people were assigned to polling stations located inside rival gang turf, deterring participation. After a 2012 truce between the government and gangs, however, turnout rebounded in these violent areas and votes shifted toward the ruling party, suggesting that gangs began facilitating electoral engagement in exchange for political benefits.

3.3.3 Corruption

Corruption is widely recognised as one of the most serious crime-related challenges of our time, not only for its corrosive effects on governance, economic performance, political and civil trust (Albanese 2022, Ajzenman 2021, Elliott 1997), but also because it serves as a strategic resource for organised crime. Rather than being a mere by-product of illicit activity, corruption is deliberately cultivated and deployed by criminal organisations to achieve specific goals: to obstruct law enforcement, influence political decisions, gain access to state resources, and secure impunity. In this sense, corruption constitutes a functional pillar of organised crime's survival and expansion.

Albanese (2025) offers compelling empirical evidence of this dynamic through a comparative analysis of over 500 prosecuted corruption cases from the United States and 50 other countries using SHERLOC, the UN's legal database on organised crime. His findings reveal that corruption often facilitates organised criminal activity by weakening regulatory oversight, protecting illegal enterprises from state intervention, and enabling transnational operations.

Similarly, Buscaglia and Van Dijk (2005) argue that organised crime and corruption are symbiotic phenomena, flourishing in institutional environments where the mechanisms of state and civil society control are weak or compromised. Their cross-national analysis identifies structural vulnerabilities that make countries more susceptible to both forms of complex crime, and emphasises that these two forces reinforce each other over time.

Organised criminal groups rely on this strategic resource to distort democratic and judicial institutions. Bribery and informal influence allow them to secure public contracts, shape policing priorities, or avoid prosecution (Gamba et al. 2018, Finckenauer 2005). In political contexts, criminal actors may support particular candidates or parties in exchange for regulatory protection or favourable policies. Accardo et al. (2023), for instance, find that higher electoral competition can increase the influence of special interest groups – including criminal organisations – on policymaking. These dynamics compromise state autonomy and turn public institutions into arenas of collusion.

Corruption also enables more systemic, long-term forms of institutional capture. In the Italian case, Barone and Narciso (2015) find that municipalities with mafia infiltration are more likely to receive public subsidies and in larger amounts, and show that organised crime fosters episodes of corruption within public administration. Similarly, Daniele and Geys (2015) show that mafia infiltration reduces the quality of elected officials — often measured by lower education levels — suggesting that criminal networks may help promote more pliable or complicit candidates. The long-term consequences of such corruption are substantial: Pinotti (2015) estimates that organised crime in Italy has reduced GDP per capita by 16% over a 30-year period, highlighting the deep institutional and developmental toll of entrenched criminal influence.

This corruption-organised crime nexus also distorts private economic behaviour. Mallon and Fainshmidt (2022) show that in contexts of pervasive extortion by organised crime, entrepreneurs often choose to operate in the informal sector to avoid becoming targets. By staying off the radar of both state and criminal actors, informal firms seek to minimise exposure to predatory demands. This highlights how criminal organisations not only exploit existing institutions but also reshape incentives within them, creating shadow institutional environments that constrain formal economic activity.

Finally, despite broad consensus on the harm caused by corruption, there is less agreement on the most effective tools for combating it. One line of research stresses the importance of political institutions — particularly elections — as mechanisms for curbing rent-seeking and holding public officials accountable (Ferraz and Finan 2008, 2011, Bobonis et al. 2016). Another strand focuses on judicial and prosecutorial capacity, suggesting that strong legal consequences can deter public malfeasance (Becker 1968, Becker and Stigler 1974). Recent empirical work has also explored the impact of transparency and oversight mechanisms. For example, Avis et al. (2018) analyse Brazil's randomised audit programme and find that previous audits reduce future corruption by 8% and increase the likelihood of legal action by 20%. These findings suggest that anti-corruption policy can be effective when it raises the perceived legal and reputational costs of misconduct, reinforcing both political and judicial accountability.

3.3.4 Trust

The presence of organised crime can undermine trust between citizens and the state. In areas where gangs impose extra-legal taxes and intimidate residents, individuals may see formal institutions as unable or unwilling to provide security. They may avoid contacting the police or going to court, which hinders the rule of law (Blattman et al. 2025). Citizens might even perceive some criminal organisations as more reliable than government agents, at least in terms of dispute resolution, an outcome documented in some neighbourhoods of Medellín and Rio de Janeiro (Blattman et al. 2025, Blattman 2025, Magaloni et al. 2020).

Empirical studies across different contexts confirm this pattern. Using LAPOP data for Colombia (2004–2010), Blanco and Ruiz (2013) find that crime victimisation, bribery, and armed conflict reduce satisfaction with democracy and trust in institutions – a result consistent with prior work on Mexico (Blanco 2012). Corbacho et al. (2015) show that crime victimisation significantly lowers trust in the local police across Latin America, although it does not consistently affect horizontal trust. Similarly, Singer et al. (2019), using data from the United States, Mexico, Argentina, and Brazil, find that fear of crime – triggered by victimisation – systematically reduces trust in the police, courts, and criminal justice institutions. In Italy, Rolla and Justino (2022) show that exposure to organised crime weakens political participation and both institutional and interpersonal trust, largely due to fear, resignation, and frustration with the state's inability to act. Nonetheless, recent findings suggest a more complex picture: Campedelli et al. (2023) demonstrate that exposure to news about organised crime can sometimes produce a 'rally effect', temporarily increasing trust in state institutions and perceptions of government performance.

4 Policy Responses

Addressing organised crime and reducing the power and reach of criminal organisations requires a careful balance between supply-side enforcement — aimed at reducing the presence and operational capacity of criminal groups — and demand-side prevention — focused on lowering the incentives and opportunities for individuals to engage in illicit activities. This section reviews the main categories of interventions, evaluating their effectiveness in both the short and long term, and highlighting empirical evidence, particularly causal findings, on outcomes and unintended consequences. The analysis covers the most documented cases, yet it aims to build a broad understanding of what works in the fight against organised crime. Ultimately, the effectiveness of these policies depends on several factors: the type of criminal organisation, its level of legitimacy, the profitability of its illicit markets, and the state's capacity to implement enforcement with due process and maintain control over the prison system (Blattman 2025, Magaloni et al. 2020, Alarcon Barrera and Sviatschi 2025, Schargrodsky and Tobon 2025).

4.1 Enforcement and State Capacity Approaches

Supply-side strategies aim to directly suppress criminal organisations through policing, military force, legal action, and institutional reforms. These interventions address the immediate 'supply' of organised crime by incapacitating or deterring perpetrators. Evidence suggests that traditional crackdowns can sometimes backfire by provoking violent adaptation, whereas more focused and accountable enforcement can yield better outcomes.

4.1.1 Policing, Crackdowns, and 'Kingpin' Strategies

Conventional enforcement often involves aggressive policing, raids, and the 'kingpin' strategy of eliminating top criminal leaders. In Latin America, governments have frequently deployed militarised crackdowns (e.g. 'mano dura' policies in Central America, large-scale cartel offensives in Mexico and Colombia, and heavy weaponry in police patrolling in Brazil and Colombia, among others). These approaches seek to fragment and weaken criminal groups, but research indicates that they can trigger violent retaliation and organisational fragmentation. When kingpins are arrested or killed, criminal hierarchies destabilise and factions fight for dominance, leading to surges in violence. This is particularly the case in contexts with highly lucrative markets — such as drug trafficking — where demand for illicit goods remains strong despite increased enforcement (Castillo et al. 2020).

For example, the beheading of Mexican drug cartels has been shown to increase the homicide rates in the affected areas in the short-run (Calderón et al. 2015, Lindo and Padilla-Romo 2018). Similarly, broader data from Mexico's drug war demonstrate that confrontational crackdowns led to turf wars: intensified law enforcement activity fragmented cartels and escalated violence both locally and in adjacent communities (Atuesta and Ponce 2017, Dell 2015). These unintended consequences can explain a substantial share of the homicide increases during Mexico's 2006–2010 drug war. Military policing approaches have proven ineffective as well. In Cali, Colombia, a large military policing intervention in areas with entrenched organised crime did not reduce crime and raised concerns about human rights violations (Blair and Weintraub 2023).

In essence, 'divide and conquer' tactics may temporarily disrupt cartels, but they risk violent reconfiguration of criminal markets rather than elimination of illicit activity. Importantly, these negative effects can persist: even if the immediate shock of a crackdown dissipates, newly formed splinter groups continue to drive elevated violence in the long run (Atuesta and Ponce 2017). Enforcement that weakens one group can invite new entrants or gangs to fill the void, perpetuating cycles of conflict.

Beyond violence, heavy-handed crackdowns can undermine the legitimacy of the state. In Medellín, Colombia, intensified police presence led gangs to strategically respond by providing more order and governance in their neighbourhoods — albeit to protect their drug rents rather than altruistically (Blattman et al. 2025). In Central America, mano dura policies in the 2000s — mass arrests of suspected gang members based primarily on appearance or place of residence — resulted in few convictions, yet had deeply counterproductive effects. These sweeps eroded trust in authorities, reinforced the stigmatisation of marginalised communities, and paradoxically accelerated gang recruitment by fuelling resentment and a sense of solidarity among targeted youth (InSight Crime 2010). Moreover, the absence of effective state control over prisons further enabled the consolidation and expansion of gang structures.

One of the most prominent recent examples of an intensive territorial recovery effort is the 2022 intervention in El Salvador. Under a declared state of emergency, the government launched a sweeping operation aimed at reclaiming control over gang-dominated areas. The strategy included the deployment of military forces, the creation of security perimeters, and the mass arrest of suspected gang members. The core objective was to dismantle entrenched gang networks and restore state authority in neighbourhoods where these groups had exercised near-complete control for years.

Melnikov et al. (2025) analyse how the same gang territories and nearby areas they studied during the period 1996-2019 in Melnikov et al. (*forthcoming*) look after the crackdown by using geocoded surveys in 2022 and 2023. The study finds that after the intervention, previously gang-controlled neighbourhoods experienced a complete removal of mobility restrictions. Moreover, recruitment also declines significantly. Before the crackdown, roughly 63% of residents reported that teenagers in their communities were being recruited by gangs; that figure dropped to just 8% following the intervention. Although income disparities between these areas and other parts of the city remain, the gap was cut in half — largely due to improved access to jobs outside former gang strongholds. Still, residents now reported to face discrimination in the labour market, as employers often still associate these neighbourhoods with gang involvement. To test this, in 2024 the researchers conducted an experiment with 400 firms and found that, even when applicants had identical qualifications, those from stigmatised areas were systematically less likely to be chosen. In terms of state legitimacy and access to public security, the study also highlights that past experiences of police abuse — reported by about 20% of respondents — significantly reduce people's willingness to seek help from law enforcement. This lingering mistrust, along with persistent stigma and labour market exclusion, may present ongoing challenges for reintegration and the restoration of effective state presence in these communities.

While this early evidence suggests that the crackdown has weakened gang structures in El Salvador, more research is needed to assess its long-term impact on criminal activity. Moreover, it remains unclear whether El Salvador's experience can be generalised to other settings. In this particular case, gangs operated primarily through coercion, held little legitimacy among the population, and relied on extortion — a business that was neither highly profitable nor fuelled by increasing demand. Unlike other criminal groups, they were not known for providing public goods or community services that might generate local support. In contrast, in contexts where criminal organisations enjoy higher levels of legitimacy or operate within more lucrative markets, such as drug trafficking, the effectiveness of similar strategies may be more limited. Additionally, without strong due process safeguards, comprehensive state control over prisons, and robust rehabilitation programmes, the long-term reintegration of incarcerated individuals is likely to fall short. This underscores the need for further research on effective reintegration strategies and the importance of more humane prison systems — particularly in low- and middle-income countries. Moreover, more evidence is needed to understand how the recruitment, training, and oversight of police officers, as well as the role of intelligence-led policing, can help reduce the risk of escalating violence during crackdowns or community interventions. In this regard, recent evidence from the United States suggests that targeted police training in de-escalation, procedural justice, and community engagement can significantly improve police-community relations and reduce the use of force without compromising public safety (e.g. Owens et al. 2018).

4.1.2 Targeted Policing and Focused Deterrence

In contrast to indiscriminate crackdowns, more targeted and intelligence-driven policing has shown promise in curbing organised violence without broad collateral damage. One such strategy is focused deterrence, which concentrates enforcement and social services on the small number of individuals or groups driving violent crime. Pioneered in US cities (e.g. the Boston Ceasefire gang intervention), focused deterrence involves directly communicating to gang members that violence will bring swift, certain punishment while offering assistance (job training, counselling) for those who choose an exit path (Abt 2019, Kennedy 2011). This 'carrot-and-stick' approach, often implemented via call-in meetings between gang members, police, and community leaders, seems to achieve success in reducing urban gang violence (Braga et al. 2019). Nonetheless, large-sample causal evidence is still lacking.

These programmes leverage community legitimacy and credible enforcement to fundamentally alter offenders' cost-benefit calculations: gang members are offered a way out of violence, but also warned that any continued violent activity will bring unified law enforcement attention. Sophisticated, organised criminal structures might require a focused deterrence approach that goes beyond the traditional attention on violence and homicides. The main reason being that often criminal groups grow stronger with peace — as their businesses thrive (Blattman et al. 2025, Brown et al. 2025). The broader idea is that of conditional repression — as opposed to indiscriminate repression — to discipline the behaviour of gangs or criminal organisations, not only on violence but also on extortion or other socially costly behaviours such as recruitment of children (e.g. Lessing 2017b, Alarcón Barrera and Sviatschi 2025).

Other policing innovations include hot-spots policing (deploying patrols to crime micro-locations) and community policing (building police-community trust to improve intelligence and co-production of security). Hot-spots policing strategies have reduced street crime in various cities, though their specific impact on organised crime (gangs and extortion networks) is less clear, may require sustained presence to prevent displacement, and has not been evidenced in Latin American cities with moderate to heavy presence of organised crime (Blattman et al. 2021, Collazos et al. 2021). Community-oriented policing, which has been piloted in some Latin American contexts, aims to rebuild legitimacy by making police more accountable and responsive to residents. The idea is that when citizens trust authorities, they are more willing to report crimes and resist criminal intimidation (Abril et al. 2024). Yet, the evidence suggests that improving police-community relations is difficult to achieve in areas long dominated by gangs (Blair et al. 2021). The broader lesson is that professionalising police forces — through better training, oversight, and community engagement — is a necessary complement to any enforcement strategy. Abusive or corrupt policing not only fails to dismantle criminal groups; it can actively drive civilians into the arms of those groups for 'protection', undercutting the state's authority (Magaloni et al. 2020). Thus, building a capable and trusted law enforcement apparatus is a long-term project central to any supply-side response.

4.1.3 Judicial Reforms and Institutional Integrity

Because organised crime often thrives on weak institutions, strengthening the justice system and governance is another critical supply-side response. This includes anti-corruption measures, legal reforms, and administrative actions to root out criminal influence from public offices. A striking example comes from Italy's effort to combat mafia infiltration of local governments: under a 1991 law, the national government can dismiss municipal councils and replace them with temporary administrators if there is evidence of mafia control. Research on this intervention (often called commissioner dissolutions) shows encouraging results: in affected Italian municipalities, the removal of corrupt local officials was followed by higher social capital and economic growth, including significant increases in employment, new firm formation, and property values, especially in sectors previously dominated by mafia cartels (Buonanno et al. 2024, Fenizia and Saggio 2024). Notably, this intervention did not lead to an increase in violence. Rather, mafia-linked violence decreased following the dismissal of the city councils (Baraldi et al. 2024). The implication is that freeing local governance from criminal capture can unleash legitimate economic activity that organised crime had been suppressing (e.g. through extortion and cartel control of contracts), highlighting the potential long-term development gains from reclaiming captured institutions.

However, institutional reforms face challenges of sustainability. In Italy, the positive effects of city council dismissals may fade if oversight is not maintained — mafia networks sometimes re-infiltrate local governments once the temporary administrators leave. Similarly, in Latin America, attempts to purge corrupt officials or police have had mixed success; new corrupt actors can emerge if underlying incentives (low salaries, political protection for criminals) remain (Ungar 2011). This suggests that one-off purges or takeovers need to be paired with deeper institutional changes. Those include improving salaries and meritocratic recruitment for police and judges, reforming criminal codes to expedite prosecutions, and providing better protection for judges, prosecutors, and witnesses who take on organised crime cases (Dahlström et al. 2012). Legal innovations like specialised anti-mafia prosecution units, witness protection programmes, and laws that criminalise membership in illicit associations (e.g. RICO statutes or conspiracy laws) can increase the state's fight against sophisticated criminal networks. Indeed, the mere signal of credible enforcement can deter criminals: evidence from the United States indicates that when the government successfully prosecutes high-level criminals (or confiscates their assets), it raises the perceived risk of doing illicit business (Levin 2013). Yet if prosecutions appear politicised or selective, they can backfire, eroding public trust. The integrity and capacity of institutions — police, courts, local governments — therefore form the backbone of an effective supply-side response. Without well-functioning institutions, aggressive policing campaigns or dramatic arrests become short-lived 'wins' that do not fundamentally diminish organised crime in the long run.

4.1.4 Prisons and Rehabilitation

An often-overlooked arena of the fight against organised crime is the prison system (e.g. Schargrodsky and Tobon 2025). In many countries, especially Latin America, prisons have become incubators and headquarters for organised gangs — a direct consequence of mass incarceration policies and weak prison governance (e.g. Lessing 2017a, Lessing and Denyer Willis 2019, Skarbek 2011, 2012). Thus, improving prison management and investing in rehabilitation are key policy responses on the supply side. One crucial step is to prevent prisons from serving as crime hubs: this may involve segregating the most influential crime leaders under high-security regimes to curtail their communication. Italy's hardline prison regime, which strictly isolates mafia bosses, exemplifies an attempt to cut the command and control that kingpins can exert from behind bars (Barbarino and Mastrobuoni 2014). While harsh, such measures aim to disrupt criminal networks' ability to coordinate violence and extortion on the outside. In Latin America, by contrast, overcrowded prisons with minimal surveillance have enabled jailed kingpins to effectively run their organisations remotely. The policy lesson is that without proper prison controls, tough sentencing can unintentionally strengthen organised crime by concentrating and connecting its members.

Reforms to prison conditions and inmate rehabilitation can mitigate these risks (Tobón 2022). Reducing overcrowding and separating rival factions can lower violence within prisons (prison violence often spills over into street violence when riots or orders for revenge occur). Additionally, offering education, job training, and re-entry support to inmates — many of whom are low-level gang members — may reduce their likelihood of returning to crime after release. Rigorous evaluations of rehabilitation programmes are still limited in the context of organised crime, but evidence from related contexts is instructive. For example, cognitive-behavioural therapy (CBT) programmes for high-risk violent offenders (discussed more below) have achieved long-term reductions in reoffending by teaching emotional regulation and non-violent conflict resolution. In one study, Blattman et al. (2017) worked with Liberian ex-combatants and found that a combination of therapy and short-run economic assistance caused a sizable drop in criminal behaviour.

4.2 Prevention and Community Focused Approaches

Pure enforcement, even when refined, cannot by itself eliminate organised crime, especially in societies where social and economic conditions make illicit livelihoods attractive. Demand-side strategies address the underlying factors that generate support for, or acquiescence to, organised crime. These include poverty and inequality, youth marginalisation, lack of legitimate opportunities, and community disempowerment.

By reducing the demand for participation in criminal activities (or the demand for the illicit goods and services that organised crime provides), these approaches aim for more sustainable, long-term reductions in organised crime. Below we survey preventive interventions ranging from economic development to violence mediation, emphasising evidence on their efficacy.

4.2.1 Recruitment Interventions

Another strategy to reduce the expansion of criminal organisations is to increase the cost of their operations by generating a shortage in labour supply. This approach targets the recruitment pipeline by limiting the availability of young individuals who might otherwise be drawn into criminal networks. Evidence from El Salvador supports the effectiveness of this strategy. In 2015, the government launched a school-based police intervention aimed specifically at reducing gang recruitment. The programme involved deploying 2–3 police officers during school entry and exit times to focus solely on preventing recruitment and ensuring the safety of students. According to Castro et al. (2025), the intervention led to a significant reduction in the likelihood that adolescents would be recruited into gangs or later appear in prison records. By disrupting the supply of new, low-cost recruits — particularly minors — the programme increased operational costs for gangs and contributed to a longer-term decline in extortion activities.

Several features explain the programme's success. First, the police force selected for implementation had a preventive orientation and no history of violence or abuse, which helped build trust within the community. Second, the intervention was highly focused in both timing and scope: officers concentrated their efforts on the specific windows when students were most vulnerable, without engaging in broader law enforcement duties such as tackling extortion. This narrow focus likely reduced the risk of retaliation, as the gang's immediate income sources were left untouched. This was particularly effective because newly recruited minors typically start with low-level surveillance roles — such as monitoring who enters the neighbourhood — and only later become involved in extortion. Third, the territorial structure of gangs in El Salvador — organised into semi-autonomous 'clicas' with exclusive control over specific areas — made it difficult to shift recruitment to non-intervened zones. Finally, since extortion was the gang's main revenue stream and is relatively low-margin, they faced limited financial flexibility to respond — for instance, by raising incentives to attract older recruits. Combined, these features made the intervention an effective strategy for disrupting gang recruitment while avoiding a violent backlash.

Nevertheless, further research is needed to assess whether these types of strategies can be effective in other settings — particularly where criminal organisations operate more lucrative enterprises or are structured in ways that allow them to adapt and relocate their activities in response to enforcement efforts — e.g. if labour demand is highly inelastic, organised crime might just recruit others. In these other contexts, such interventions could be complemented with strategies that alter the economic incentives for minors to join gangs — for example, by expanding access to formal employment opportunities, offering targeted social programmes, or strengthening educational pathways. Combining enforcement with approaches that address the root causes of youth vulnerability may be essential to reduce recruitment and ensure more sustainable results.

4.2.2 Broader Socioeconomic Interventions and Incentives

A robust finding in the development literature is that improving legal economic opportunities can deter involvement in crime. Organised criminal enterprises often recruit from pools of unemployed or underemployed youth who see few alternatives to the high (if risky) income of illicit work. Accordingly, governments have tried to 'dry up' the recruitment base through antipoverty programmes, education, and employment initiatives. Conditional cash transfer (CCT) programmes are a prominent example. CCTs, such as Mexico's Oportunidades or Brazil's Bolsa Familia, provide cash stipends to low-income households contingent on behaviours like children attending school. While primarily aimed at human capital and poverty, CCTs have shown spillover effects on crime reduction (e.g. Chioda et al. 2016, Machado et al. 2018).

In Peru, Sviatschi (2022a) shows that areas with coca cultivation experienced a significant decline in both coca production and child labour following the implementation of a CCT programme that provided monetary incentives to parents conditional on their children's daily school attendance. Although the programme specifically targeted school-aged children and was not designed to reduce drug production, the findings suggest that CCTs could be strategically directed toward coca-suitable districts to mitigate the adverse effects of increased returns in the illegal sector — particularly in regions with high coca prices — documented in previous sections.

In Brazil, researchers found that expanding Bolsa Familia coverage in high-violence areas was associated with lower homicide rates, particularly reductions in gun-related killings and youth victimisation (Ingram and Da Costa 2014). The mechanism is likely twofold: the added income support alleviates extreme need (reducing economic motivation for joining gangs or theft), and the emphasis on schooling keeps adolescents in structured, supervised environments. This spatial analysis of violence in Brazil concluded that policies which reduce poverty and social vulnerability tend to reduce violence, and specifically highlighted Bolsa Familia's expansion as contributing to drops in youth homicide rates.

Also focusing on Brazil, Britto et al. (2022) examine how involuntary job loss influences criminal behaviour and assesses whether unemployment insurance mitigates this effect. Leveraging administrative records that link employment histories, criminal charges, and welfare participation for the full population of Brazilian male workers, the study estimates that displacement through mass layoffs raises an individual's propensity to commit crimes by roughly 23%. Yet, the study also finds that access to unemployment benefits entirely neutralises the crime spike following job loss, with the protective effect disappearing immediately once payments cease. The study does not focus on organised crime, but given the scope of the sample, it is not unreasonable to expect some marginal organised criminals to avoid illegal activities given the extent of social support.

Beyond cash transfers, job creation and training programmes for at-risk populations are another strategy (e.g. Chioda et al. 2024). These range from youth apprenticeship schemes to initiatives providing alternative livelihoods to farmers who might otherwise participate in the drug economy (e.g. coca crop substitution programmes in Andean countries). The success of such programmes has been mixed (Londoño Mesa et al. 2024). Some agricultural substitution efforts, like Colombia's investments in coffee and cacao for former coca growers, have struggled unless paired with security improvements (farmers will not abandon coca without assurance that insurgents or traffickers won't coerce them back into it). Indeed, providing subsidies to coca farmers has, unsurprisingly, increased coca cultivation in Colombia (Prem et al. 2023). Strong social support for released offenders can sustainably reduce re-entry into criminal activities and organisations (Barrios-Fernández and García-Hombrados 2025). Job training programmes for urban youth have shown positive impacts on employment, and in some cases reductions in crime or gang involvement, yet there is wide heterogeneity in who benefits and why (Davis and Heller 2020). One likely reason is that illicit earnings often dwarf entry-level wages in the formal sector, especially for low-skilled men, so the calculus to join a gang may not drastically change unless legal jobs are sufficiently attractive in relative terms. However, there are promising examples: a large-scale programme in Honduras that combined vocational training with a temporary wage subsidy for at-risk youth significantly reduced their self-reported participation in illegal activities two years later — though community violence levels did not change dramatically (Chioda et al. 2024). Another example is the READI programme in Chicago, which combines precise targeting of at-risk youth — through administrative data and community referrals — with an intense combination of CBT, an 18-month job, and social support. The programme led to substantial and sustained reductions in shootings and homicide arrests (Bhatt et al. 2024).

It is important to note, however, that most job training programmes target individuals over the age of 18 – an age group that is typically not the primary focus of criminal recruitment. Therefore, more research is needed on interventions that target younger populations, particularly during the critical windows when recruitment into organised crime is most likely to occur. In this regard, recent research on youth involvement in organised crime in Medellín, Colombia, offers some granular insights into the beliefs and constraints

that channel adolescents toward gang life. Drawing on semi-structured interviews with leaders from more than eighty of the city's roughly four hundred drug-selling gangs, Blattman et al. (2025) document detailed organisational hierarchies, promotion ladders, earnings schedules, and recruitment tactics that reward risk-tolerant teenagers yet expose them to high probabilities of violence and incarceration. These qualitative findings framed a large-scale survey of almost 10,000 seventh-grade boys enrolled in 100 low- and middle-income public schools, allowing for an unusually integrated view of the 'demand' and 'supply' sides of the criminal labour market.

The school-based instrument elicited subjective beliefs about monetary and non-monetary returns associated with four career categories — low-skill legal, medium-skill legal, high-skill legal, and gang work — together with perceived arrest and fatality risks and the social prestige attached to each option. Standardised scales captured future orientation, impulsivity, and time preferences, while respondents also stated their personal probability of joining a gang by age 25. Combining this data with neighbourhood crime statistics, the study estimated reduced-form correlates of self-reported recruitment risk and specified a structural model of occupational choice under uncertainty.

Findings indicate that nearly one in six boys placed their likelihood of gang entry at 20% or higher. Elevated risk clustered around three systematic distortions: (i) under-estimation of lifetime earnings attainable in medium- and high-skill legal professions; (ii) overestimation of the non-pecuniary rewards — status, excitement, social capital — conferred by gang membership; and (iii) the degree of future orientation and impulsivity. A randomised information treatment that contrasted actual versus perceived returns in both monetary and non-monetary dimensions produced immediate, statistically significant reductions in stated gang-entry probabilities, underscoring the malleability of recruitment intentions when beliefs are corrected. (An ongoing field experiment is testing whether a vocational orientation and behavioural intervention effectively reduces gang entry among the highest-risk adolescents identified in the survey).

4.2.3 Youth Programmes and Cognitive Behavioural Therapy

Given the prominent role of youths in organised crime (both as perpetrators and victims), targeted youth development programmes are a key demand-side approach. These include after-school programmes, mentorship, behavioural therapy, and violence prevention curricula, often implemented in high-crime communities. The evidence from Medellín we discuss above suggests that labour market interventions — such as vocational orientation — should be implemented earlier, as individuals begin forming their expectations and making choices while still in school (Blattman et al. 2024). The rationale is to steer young people away from gangs during their formative years, build socio-emotional skills, and offer pro-social alternatives (education, sports, arts, job skills) that make gang life less appealing.

Recent rigorous studies in Latin America provide encouraging evidence on such interventions. For instance, an experiment by Dinarte-Diaz and Egana-delSol (2024) in El Salvador evaluated an after-school programme that combined academic support with cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) techniques for students in some of the country's most violent neighbourhoods. CBT sessions focused on improving self-control, coping with anger, and resisting negative peer influence. The study found measurable reductions in aggressive and disruptive behaviour in schools that received the programme, along with improvements in students' decision-making under pressure. These outcomes suggest that even in extremely violent contexts, providing a safe space after school and training youths in emotional regulation can curb the minor violent incidents and conflicts that often serve as entry points to more organised violence. This echoes findings from the United States, where CBT-oriented programmes for at-risk adolescents (such as the Becoming a Man programme in Chicago) produced sharp drops in youth arrests (Heller et al. 2017). It also parallels the Liberia study noted earlier, in which high-risk young men saw their antisocial behaviour decrease after short-term therapy and employment (Blattman et al. 2017, 2023). However, more research is needed to determine whether CBT interventions can be effective in the long run in contexts of organised crime, where much of the violence is premeditated and individuals may join not out of impulsivity, but due to other factors such as perceived safety, as well as pecuniary and non-pecuniary returns. Thus, in the context of criminal organisations, the mechanisms through which CBT operates may need to be adapted or complemented with other interventions targeting structural incentives and social dynamics.

The policy implication is that youth interventions work best as part of an ongoing support system rather than one-off inoculations. Moreover, when after-school programmes, mentoring, or counselling are continuously available through critical years, they can interrupt the school-to-gang pipeline. In particular, interventions targeting the critical ages for gang recruitment can be effective in producing long-term impacts on organised crime (Sviatschi 2022a, Castro et al. 2025). Several Latin American cities have expanded after-school sports leagues, music programmes, and tutoring in violence-plagued neighbourhoods (e.g. Medellín's network of library parks and youth centres established in the 2000s alongside its crime decline). These efforts, in tandem with improved policing, are credited with boosting social cohesion and offering youths status and belonging outside of gangs. Evaluations of some of these initiatives find reduced self-reported gang involvement and higher school retention among participants, though robust causal evidence on violent crime outcomes is still emerging. Nevertheless, the accumulation of micro-level successes points toward a preventive strategy centred on youth empowerment and psychological resilience as a valuable complement to policing. By changing attitudes and skills — instilling non-violent norms, future orientation, and conflict resolution abilities — such programmes address the 'demand' for criminal life at its source.

4.2.4 Changing Peers' Norms at Critical Ages

Other types of school-based interventions aimed at reducing early violent behaviour at critical ages have focused on shifting social norms and attitudes toward reporting violence. One example is a study conducted in Peru by Gutierrez et al. (2024), which evaluated a preventive programme targeting adolescents aged 12 to 16. Through guided tutoring sessions, the programme emphasised the importance of reporting violent incidents to enable early intervention and prevent escalation. It also incorporated a digital platform that allowed students to submit anonymous reports and promoted a less punitive, more restorative approach to conflict resolution. The intervention aimed to increase the social cost of violent and antisocial behaviour by changing peer norms around the acceptability and value of reporting such incidents. This age group was specifically targeted because it represents a critical period when youth are particularly vulnerable to recruitment into gangs or engagement in criminal activities. The underlying rationale was that fostering a school environment where reporting violence is seen as socially acceptable and supported by peers would raise the perceived risks and reputational costs associated with antisocial behaviour, both in school and in the broader community.

The results showed a significant increase in the reporting of school violence, which was accompanied by a decline in students' exposure to such incidents. Notably, students previously identified with aggressive behaviours were significantly less likely to commit crimes four years after participating in the programme. These findings suggest that interventions implemented during critical stages of youth development — by strengthening cooperative norms and deterrence from within the peer group, rather than relying solely on punitive measures or external incentives — can produce lasting reductions in criminal involvement.

4.2.5 Mediation, Negotiation, and Violence Interruption

A controversial set of demand-side responses involves directly engaging with criminal groups to negotiate a reduction in violence. These mediation or truce strategies treat violence as, in part, a problem of broken communication or strategic tit-for-tat that might be de-escalated through third-party facilitation (Blattman 2023). Examples include gang truces in El Salvador, where evidence indicates that when gangs successfully collude, divide territories, and reduce internal violence, they often repurpose the youth previously recruited for violent confrontations into other criminal activities (Brown et al. 2025). This shift allows them to expand their territorial control and scale up operations such as extortion, leading to increased financial extractions from local residents. As a result, gangs not only strengthen their economic base but also their capacity for coercion. These findings highlight a potential trade-off: while short-term reductions in violence may be achieved, they can come at the cost of long-term consolidation and territorial expansion of criminal organisations (Blattman et al. 2022). Furthermore, the truce's gains are often proved short-lived, as such equilibriums are unstable. Apart from the El Salvador example — where violence spiked after the 2012 truce ended — a similar pattern was observed in a 1990's gang truce in Los Angeles and a ceasefire in Trinidad and Tobago: temporary lulls in killings were followed by surges when the informal peace agreement broke down (Katz et al. 2016).

That said, mediation approaches are not monolithic. Violence interruption programmes like Cure Violence do not negotiate formal truces or rewards, but instead use credible community insiders to intervene in interpersonal disputes (such as retaliatory shootings) before they escalate. In some US cities and a few Latin American pilot projects (e.g. in Honduras, Mexico, and Colombia), violence interrupters have been credited with cooling down neighbourhood conflicts and preventing cycles of killings. Yet, rigorous causal evidence is still absent (e.g. Butts et al. 2015). These programmes treat violence as a contagious disease, aiming to interrupt transmission by identifying brewing 'hot' conflicts and mediating personal disputes (for instance, by separating feuding gang members or negotiating agreements to stand down). These programmes have the advantage of not requiring governments to concede any official authority to criminals (unlike formal truces), but they rely heavily on the skills and integrity of the mediators.

Finally, at the highest level, there are instances of demobilisation agreements akin to those in civil wars: encouraging entire armed groups to lay down arms in exchange for leniency or integration. Colombia's peace deals — the AUC paramilitary demobilisation in 2003–2006 and the FARC guerrilla peace accord in 2016 — can be seen in this light, as both insurgent groups were deeply involved in organised crime (e.g. drug trafficking, extortion, and illegal gold mining). These processes indeed led to large drops in violence initially, with increases in economic activity (e.g. Bernal et al. 2024, Perilla et al. 2024). However, criminal successors emerged in many zones, which reintroduced violence and criminal activities (Prem et al. 2021, 2023). The takeaway is that negotiated reductions in violence can save lives in the short term, but they must be bolstered by long-term strategies — including economic reintegration of ex-combatants, community reconciliation, changes in the economic incentives to re-engage in organised criminal activities, and security efforts to prevent splinter factions from taking over. Without those, the vacuum left by a truce or demobilisation can invite new violent actors, as we have seen in both Central America's gang truces and Colombia's post-conflict challenges.

5 Conclusion

We conclude by bringing together the main lessons, the policy guidance, and the research priorities that follow from the evidence we have reviewed. Across contexts as diverse as Italy, El Salvador, Colombia, and the eastern Congo, we have seen that what matters most is not simply a state presence but a state that effectively protects property, resolves disputes, and enforces contracts. When governments build schools or roads yet leave policing and justice weak, criminal groups step in to fill that vacuum and extract rents. Where kingpin arrests fragment those groups, violence rises, yet where governments target the most violent actors and back enforcement with credible social support, violence falls, and legal economic activity expands. The evidence suggests that economic incentives can drive recruitment: adolescents weigh the wages, status, and perceived safety offered by criminal organisations against the legal opportunities available to them. Improvements in safety, formal employment, social insurance, or conditional transfers can shift that cost-benefit calculus toward lawful activity. At the same time, criminal governance imposes broader societal costs — mobility restrictions, extortion, and electoral interference — that often persist even after overt violence declines.

These broad costs suggest that prevention strategies must go hand in hand with the strengthening of legal institutions and effective law enforcement. Police reform should advance in lockstep with professionalised prosecution services and more efficient judicial systems. Procedural deadlines, merit-based recruitment, and evidence-driven case management can increase the likelihood of conviction, thereby raising the expected cost of engaging in criminal activity. Labour policy also belongs at the centre of organised crime control. Facilitating dynamic labour markets can increase the opportunity cost of working in organised crime. For instance, evidence from Brazil shows that unemployment benefits can fully offset the crime surge that follows mass layoffs. At the same time, the evidence suggests that targeted income support and vocational training in the neighbourhoods most exposed to recruitment could strengthen that effect.

We see the highest returns when the state moves early, before young people decide to — or are forced to — join a criminal career. Causal evidence from Peru and El Salvador shows that interventions targeting the critical ages of gang recruitment can disrupt the cycle of criminal involvement and affect the operations of gangs by increasing their cost of labour. At the same time, surveys of adolescent boys in schools in Medellín show that roughly one in six expects to join a gang by age 25 because he underestimates legal earnings and overrates the status gangs confer. Low-cost information campaigns and career-guidance modules embedded in middle school curricula could correct those beliefs and shift stated intentions away from crime. When early interventions fail and youth end up incarcerated, governments must treat prisons as hubs of desistance, not schools of crimes or criminal hubs. Cognitive-behavioural therapy combined with market-relevant training and strong social support cuts recidivism among high-risk inmates, but only if prison managers exercise significant supervision and keep senior leaders from directing violence on the outside.

Criminal taxation merits the same attention as criminal violence. Extortion acts as a regressive tax on micro-firms and poor households. Interventions that make extortion more visible to enforcement — such as reducing cash handling — or efforts to make extortion more costly — such as adaptations of focused deterrence — could reduce the incidence of criminal taxation. Community cohesion amplifies these formal strategies. Where traditional institutions in Mexico or strong neighbourhood associations in El Salvador already resolve disputes, gangs struggle to recruit and to tax. Municipal grants that fund local dispute boards and public spaces can foster that resilience. Important gaps remain. We still know little about interventions that shift adolescent expectations and behaviour at scale. Ongoing work should test the impact of peer mentoring, efforts to strengthen cooperative norms within schools, early deterrence interventions, labour-market simulations, and school-based vocational tracks. These interventions should measure not only their effects on recruitment but also their influence on norms, perceived earnings, social status, and risk tolerance. Mental-health burdens of criminal exposure also need rigorous study; embedding trauma modules in household surveys and randomising therapy through schools or clinics would reveal both prevalence and cost-effectiveness.

Intergenerational effects represent another blind spot. Administrative data that follows children of gang-affected households into adulthood would clarify whether criminal shocks propagate disadvantage. We must also learn how peer norms evolve and how to address them at the right ages to achieve sustained protective environments. Also, scholars should put a focus on courts to understand which legal reforms raise conviction certainty without eroding due process. Furthermore, researchers ought to measure the outcomes that residents experience — mobility, extortion payments, recruitment, perceptions of authority — rather than rely solely on homicide counts. Primary data collection, or alternative measures such as night-time lights and cell-phone mobility data offer objective proxies that complement administrative records. Moreover, structural models calibrated with experimental data can simulate equilibrium trade-offs: when one policy reduces violence, does extortion increase allowing criminal organisations to grow stronger? When recruitment falls, do gang wages rise, tempting other youth to join? Such models can inform balanced policy mixes.

Additionally, existing research has paid limited attention to how gender influences organised crime dynamics. It influences who is recruited, the roles individuals occupy, their exposure to violence, and how communities experience the broader effects of criminal activity. Addressing these gendered patterns is essential for developing more effective and inclusive interventions. Finally, it is important to highlight the lack of research on organised crime in West Africa, where qualitative reports suggest that criminal organisations are an increasingly pressing concern. Future work should aim to better understand the dynamics of organised crime in this context, including its drivers, forms of governance, and socioeconomic impacts.

Our review leaves us both cautious and optimistic. Organised crime blocks investment, skews labour markets, and weakens democracy. Yet, research suggests that governments can mitigate these harms when they combine credible enforcement, opportunity expansion, and justice reform. The task now is to heed the minds of adolescents at the threshold of recruitment, to ease the psychological wounds violence leaves behind, and to trace the long shadow that criminal rule casts across generations. With rigorous scholarship tied to policy experimentation, we can design interventions that not only lower today's violence but also broaden tomorrow's economic and civic opportunities.

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